MCP PRODUCTION · SPEC REVISION 2026-07-28

Diagnose a missing approval

The diagnosis sheet from lesson 3.1: what an input_required result, a displayed form or a retry each establish, with practice cases and their answers.

A standalone companion to lesson 3.1. No laboratory or prior lesson is needed. Consider a tool that proposes publishing a specific note to a specific board and requires a decision before publication.

```
sequenceDiagram
    participant C as Client
    participant S as Server
    participant U as User
    C-->>S: Propose note (request A)
    S-->>C: input_required + form + opaque state
    C-->>U: Show target and exact text
    alt Submitted decision
        U-->>C: Accept, decline, or cancel
        C-->>S: Same operation + answer + exact state (request B)
        S-->>S: Validate identity, subject, lifetime, and lifecycle
        S-->>C: Application outcome
    else No retry
        Note over C,S: No new decision reaches the server
    end
```

The diagram's proposal storage and publication policy are illustrative application choices. The wire pattern carries the input exchange; it does not establish that a human actually interacted with the client.

OBSERVATION	WHAT IT ESTABLISHES	NEXT USEFUL CHECK
`resultType: input_required`	The operation needs another input step	Inspect `inputRequests` and client support
Form displayed	The client presented a question	Determine whether an answer was submitted
Retry sent	Another exchange was attempted	Match input keys and original operation context
Different RPC ID	A separate exchange is being correlated	Preserve the business operation identity
Intact continuation	Integrity verification may succeed	Still check caller, subject, expiry and consumption
No follow-up request	No new input was received	Keep unapproved work from committing; enforce lifetime
Missing answer after acceptance	Client outcome remains uncertain	Query the application's authoritative status/receipt

Practice cases

1. The server returns a form but the client never displays it. Inspect the advertised form capability and the branch that handles input-required results. Increasing a timeout does not supply a missing decision.

2. The retry carries the approval but changes the target board. Reject a continuation that no longer matches the approved subject; inspect the effect as well as the response so a late error cannot hide a premature write.
3. Acceptance was sent and the connection ended without a final response. Find the application's outcome evidence before creating a new operation. A missing response is compatible with a committed effect.

Do not interpret client display names or user-entered identity as verified caller identity. Do not infer human participation from an acceptance payload.

Primary sources checked 2026-09-09: MRTR, elicitation.

> **Where this goes next.** Lessons 3.2 to 3.4 build the input-required result and the client retry with Multi Round-Trip Requests, then test refusal, abandonment and a restart mid-approval in lab 3. The course: runsclean.com/courses/mcp-production/